

Tamarind and chipotle sweet-hot sauce

One of my favorite chiles, the chipotle, adds heat and smokiness—a perfect combination for a barbecue-type sauce. Tamarind imparts a unique fruity-sweet tartness. This is an outstanding marinade for tofu. Marinate overnight, then grill on the barbecue. My trick is to let the flames lick the tofu and crisp it slightly, then continue to cook until heated through. Top with additional sauce, reduced until thickened.

2 large chipotle chiles or 1 teaspoon chipotle chile powder, or less to taste	1 tablespoon olive oil
1 cup canned peeled tomatoes [250g]	1 small onion, finely chopped
½ cup cider vinegar [125ml]	2 garlic cloves, minced
½ cup balsamic vinegar [125ml]	½ cup unrefined cane sugar [100g]
½ teaspoon cinnamon	1 tablespoon molasses
½ teaspoon paprika	1 tablespoon tamarind paste
½ teaspoon ground coriander	1 tablespoon tomato paste
½ teaspoon ground cumin	½ teaspoon salt
¼ teaspoon ground cloves	2 pounds extra-firm tofu, pressed to remove excess water [1kg]

1. **Crack** open the chipotle chiles and remove the seeds, ribs, and stems. Soak in 2 cups [500ml] hot water until soft, 45 minutes to 1 hour. Chop the chiles and set aside. Reserve the soaking liquid. In a blender or food processor, puree the chiles with the tomatoes.
2. Meanwhile, in a nonreactive medium saucepan, **combine** the cider vinegar, balsamic vinegar, cinnamon, paprika, coriander, cumin, and cloves. Bring to a boil, reduce the heat to medium-low, and simmer, uncovered, until reduced by half, 10 to 15 minutes.

3. In a large skillet, **heat** the olive oil over medium heat. Add the onion and cook until golden brown, 5 to 7 minutes. Add the garlic and cook another minute, or until soft and fragrant. Stir in the reduced vinegar mixture, sugar, molasses, tamarind paste, tomato paste, salt, chipotle-tomato puree, and ½ cup [125ml] of the reserved chile soaking liquid. Bring to a boil, stirring well. Reduce the heat to low, cover, and cook for 20 to 30 minutes, until thickened. For a thicker sauce, cook uncovered for the last 5 to 10 minutes. Strain the sauce through a fine-mesh strainer. Season with additional salt to taste.
4. **Cut** the tofu into 8 cutlets. Put the tofu cutlets in 2 large heavy-duty, sealable freezer bags. Divide the sauce between the bags, making sure the tofu is well coated. Seal the bags and lay them on a platter or tray. Refrigerate overnight.
5. Light a medium-hot fire in a barbecue grill or preheat the broiler with the rack set 5 to 6 inches [13 to 15 cm] from the heat. Grill or broil the tofu cutlets, turning once and **brushing** with sauce, until they are crisp and lightly charred on the outside, 3 to 5 minutes.
6. Quickly reheat the remaining sauce. **Spoon** some of it over the grilled tofu cutlets and pass the remainder on the side.

MAKES ABOUT 2 CUPS [500ML]